

Indian women are burdened with both agriculture and unpaid work, adding up to 12-14 hours per day of work. Further, women's caregiving responsibilities intensify with climate change which may lead to displacement, injuries, and illnesses.

Several studies show that climate change-related impacts on health are greater for women than men, especially in low and middle-income countries like India. In both rural and urban contexts, women are more vulnerable to heat stress and air pollution. Pregnant women are found to be at greater risk as these factors are known to increase the risk of miscarriages and premature births. Additionally, climate displacement affects women's access to sanitation and reproductive healthcare services.

98 | For a long time, the role of women in climate change was little understood. Despite the differentiated impacts of climate change on women, it is necessary to underline that women are not "victims" of climate change. Rather, women are nimble at adapting to the crisis, for example, by practising climate-resilient agriculture, preserving indigenous knowledge like rotating crops and preserving native seeds, implementing water conservation and reuse strategies, and waste management strategies.

Women are key to building climate resilience and they must be at the centre of India's climate agenda. India's National Action Plan for Climate Change (NAPCC) acknowledges the disproportionate effects of climate change on women and the need to promote gender in climate policy. However, State Action Plans on Climate Change, which are sub-national plans for implementing the NAPCC are inconsistent across states and many states treat women as a vulnerable group without pro-



ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA

viding targeted strategies. There has been some improvement in recent years, particularly in states like Uttarakhand, Odisha, Assam and Madhya Pradesh.

In terms of policymaking, there has been progress in improving women's access to drinking water infrastructure in rural areas under the Jal Jeevan Mission and access to clean fuels under the Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana, but gaps remain.

To enhance climate justice for women, India must promote the participation and leadership of women at all levels of climate policy and negotiations. It must prioritise the insights and knowledge of women in climate

strategies. It must provide targeted training and employment opportunities for women in green sectors. It must improve gender-disaggregated data and monitoring frameworks on climate.

It must ensure that women who are dependent on climate-vulnerable sectors like agriculture and fisheries can access adaptation finance and technology. It must tap into the private sector to bridge climate financing gaps.

Climate action requires a 'whole-of-society' approach and women cannot be left out of it. **BT**

Views are personal